



difference. Everything is so organised. Each game is videotaped. There are top match officials officiating, and trainers who take care of the players. When you have all the facilities in abundance, you will always be able to perform better," he tells *Sportstar*.

The former India all-rounder explained how winning the U-19 World Cup in 2000 changed the trajectory of his career, and expects the same for the current crop.

"Immediately after winning, six of our names came in the Challenger Trophy [squad list]. We were in the same teams as Sachin Tendulkar, Sourav Ganguly and Rahul Dravid. That was undoubtedly the best gift a youngster could get. The experience of

playing with national team players turns you from a boy to a man. Even now, guys like Mhatre and Vaibhav Suryavanshi will be taken to higher-level cricket, and if they perform well there, in a year they could be given a chance to play for India," Sodhi said.

Mhatre and Suryavanshi are already on the senior radar.

Mhatre has two First-Class hundreds for Mumbai and was drafted by the Chennai Super Kings in the Indian Premier League (IPL), where he excelled. Suryavanshi debuted for Bihar at 12 and later smashed a 35-ball hundred for Rajasthan Royals at 14.

A couple of others have also made their domestic bow before this edition, but are yet to match the feats of these two. For most,

though, the leap from U-19 cricket to the domestic grind is far less straightforward. "The World Cup can give you a ray

Taking the big leap: Shubman Gill arrived at the U-19 World Cup as vice-captain in 2018, fast-tracked on the back of a dazzling Ranji first impression: a debut fifty, followed by an attacking 129 for Punjab. PTI

of hope that you can make it big in Indian cricket. But it is not the end of the journey. You can't sit and wait for things to happen. The onus is on the players to keep performing. The expectations are there. If there is no improvement, people will forget," Sodhi said.

The pathway has pitfalls, too. Prithvi Shaw (**pic, left**) and Manjot Kalra, both from the 2018 batch, are recent examples. Shaw struggled to cement his place despite an early breakthrough, with injuries stalling his momentum. Kalra's rise after his 2018 final hundred was derailed by an age-fraud allegation soon after.

Prashant Shetty, who has coached Mhatre since he was nine, also witnessed Shaw's rise from close quarters. "In Under-19, you are not competing with that many



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